The discovery of the structure of DNA (deoxyribonucleic acid) in 1953 is one of the key scientific breakthroughs to date. It offered the key to understanding the very building blocks of life and explained how genetic information is stored and transferred. Englishman Francis Crick and American James Watson famously celebrated their joint discovery in a low-key fashion at their local pub in Cambridge, followed by a letter published in the journal *Nature*. Their discovery had enormous potential for scientific advances and had an important impact on many fields of research, from medicine to forensic science, taxonomy, and agriculture. The ramifications of their work still reverberate today, as methods of handling genetic material advance and we learn more about how individual genes operate.

Crick and Watson's breakthrough was the culmination of decades of research by numerous scientists, including Rosalind Franklin and Maurice Wilkins. While Crick and Watson worked with 3-D models to figure out how the components of DNA fitted together, at King's College, London, Franklin and Wilkins were developing methods of X-raying DNA to view its structure. Watson had seen examples of Franklin's work that hinted at DNA's helical shape shortly before he and Crick announced their breakthrough.

In 1962 Crick, Watson, and Wilkins were awarded the Nobel Prize for Physiology or Medicine. Franklin, who died in 1958, never received recognition for her part in the discovery during her lifetime, although Crick and Watson openly acknowledged that her work was essential to their success.